

Carpenter Center: LeCorbusier's only American work

The Carpenter Center for the Visual Arts at Harvard is the only American building by the most influential architect of this century, the Swiss-French Le Corbusier. It lurks among the sedate buildings of Quincy street, in Dylan Thomas' phrase, like a dog among the fairies. Two fat curved wings of art studios flank a twisted square tower, while a ramp at third-floor height rushes, like a Lewis Carroll character, from nowhere to nowhere.

When a building refuses to look like other buildings, it's upsetting and we try to trim its wings by finding something it does look like. "A drunk being taken to the station by two burly policemen," "banjos, back-to-back," "a cubist guitar from one of the master's own landscapes," — those were early appraisals.

Corbusier's own office staff called the big curved studio that jabs toward Harvard Yard "the punch." Eduard Sekler, the noted Harvard architectural historian, finds another image in Le Corbusier's paintings: a motif of two wine glasses, side by side, one upside down so that the two shapes interlock. Sekler traces this motif through many paintings as a sort of "visual word." It

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closely resembles the plan of the Carpenter Center.

Creation, in other words, is a mysterious event, and architects do think of other things than toilet layouts. Prof. Sekler's analysis is contained in a new book, long awaited in the architectural community, called "Le Corbusier at Work: the Genesis of the Carpenter Center for the Visual Arts" (Harvard University Press, \$35). More than 200 drawings and photos were gathered and many of the original participants interviewed. The result is perhaps the richest study of one building's design ever published, as well as a candid look at a great genius and genuine oddball at work.

The heart of the book is the narrative, by coauthor William Curtis. Everything begins as usual, with a committee report, the Brown Report: Harvard needs a visual arts center. A sudden donor appears, St. Vrain Carpenter, an Oregon pear farmer.

But what is there for him to donate? A theater? No the Loeb's want to give

that. Carpenter settles for the visual arts center. Who will be the architect? J.L. Sert, dean of the graduate school of design, writes a letter to president Nathan Pusey: "There is no Le Corbusier building in this country, which is as strange as if there were no Picasso paintings in our museums." The game is afoot.

What follows is the most convincing account I know of a creative process in architecture. It's all here: The speed of design breakthroughs, of solutions "surging" as Corbusier calls it. The long doldrums of trying to solve unsolvable problems that will disappear only when someone redefines the question. The pressure and misunderstanding, the importance of time and money. The inevitable ghosts of abandoned ideas that remain, stubbornly, in the finished building, giving it much of its depth and tension. Messages and trips back and forth across the Atlantic. Pusey's passion for getting the main entrance to line up with the back door of the Faculty Club, as foolish an obsession as client every clung to.

Best of all are the day-by-day accounts of the brief periods in April 1960 and January 1961 when the building was actually created. In a series of thin, wobbly sketches the outlines begin to

appear, as if the building were coming toward us slowly through fog, or as if it were a photographic print growing clear in the developer.

Corbusier tries to pack so many lessons for the rest of us into his building that it's amazing it doesn't burst.

"He told me that the Visual Arts Center was to be his only American building, and that he would therefore put all his architectural elements in it," says Jullien de la Fuente, Corbusier's assistant in the Paris office. Even the drawings must be an object lesson: "Do the plans," Corbusier tells Jullien, "so that they will think I am a real architect." The resulting drawings are exquisite pale colored works of art, lacking words or dimensions. Le Corbusier boasts that they are "the crystallization of the architectural drawing of our epoch."

But Paul Krueger, the job captain at Sert's office who must translate them into buildable contract drawings, calls them "cartoons." And the eventual builder, Ken Leach, sums up the Master as "a theoretician, not a true practicing architect." But he and his crew were proud to work on the building.

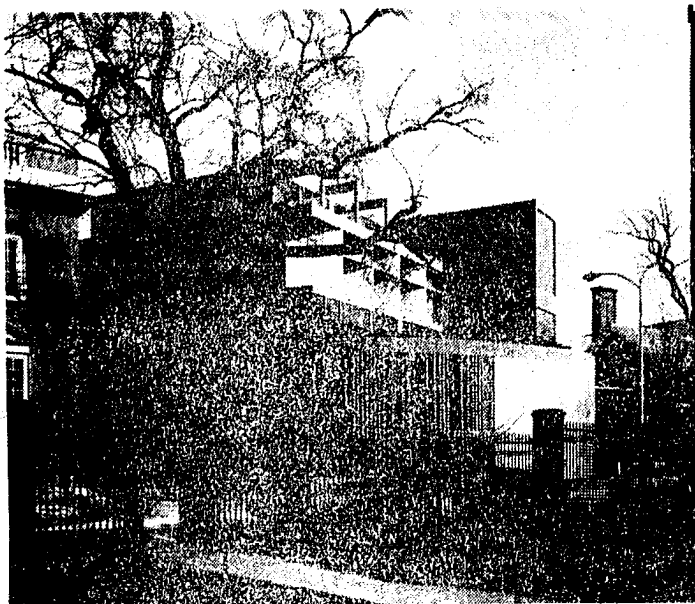
The four authors offer little in the way of serious criticism. It's taken for granted the building is a masterpiece and little is made of the nowhere ramp, the disastrous relation of the building to the ground at nearly every point, or the isolation within of one part from another. No one points out that the "new language of architecture" Corbusier meant the building to embody has been spoken by few besides himself. Sekler's essay on the building's formal ideas is very fine, but a user evaluation by Barbara Norfleet and a theoretical note by Rudolf Arnheim are thin and disappointing.

What I like best about the building, not mentioned, is its quality of seeming improvised, fluctuating, as in the lecture hall which appears to have been remodeled and turned 90 degrees from an earlier hall, although it wasn't. The center's interiors have an unsettled quality, like old industrial lofts in Paris, that makes them good places for artists.

What's important about this book is not what it tells us about the Carpenter Center, which isn't enough, but what it tells us about a great architect's creative process, which is more than enough to make it a probable classic.



View up the ramp on Quincy street side of Carpenter Center.



Oblique view of Carpenter Center from Harvard Yard.



LeCorbusier at Harvard, 1960